

THE ARCHITECT OF SHADOW FINANCE

Prescott Bush, Brown Brothers Harriman & The Financing of Totalitarian Industrial Re-Armament

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FORENSIC INVESTIGATIVE DIRECTIVE: While his father Samuel P. Bush established the prototype of domestic war procurement inside the War Industries Board of 1918, **Prescott Sheldon Bush (1895–1972)** elevated the enterprise to the transnational level. Operating as a senior managing partner of Wall Street merchant bank **Brown Brothers Harriman (BBH)** and an executive director of the **Union Banking Corporation (UBC)**, Prescott Bush directed the transatlantic financial conduit that underwrote the industrial cartels of interwar Germany—specifically the coal, steel, and weapons empire of German industrialist Fritz Thyssen (*Vereinigte Stahlwerke*). This financial collaboration persisted not only through the rise of totalitarianism in the 1930s, but continued ten months *after* the United States entered World War II, culminating in the federal seizure of Union Banking Corporation's assets in October 1942 under the **Trading with the Enemy Act**. This volume presents the declassified corporate charters, Alien Property Custodian vesting orders, banking ledgers, and intelligence files that trace the conversion of illicit wartime capital into modern political power.

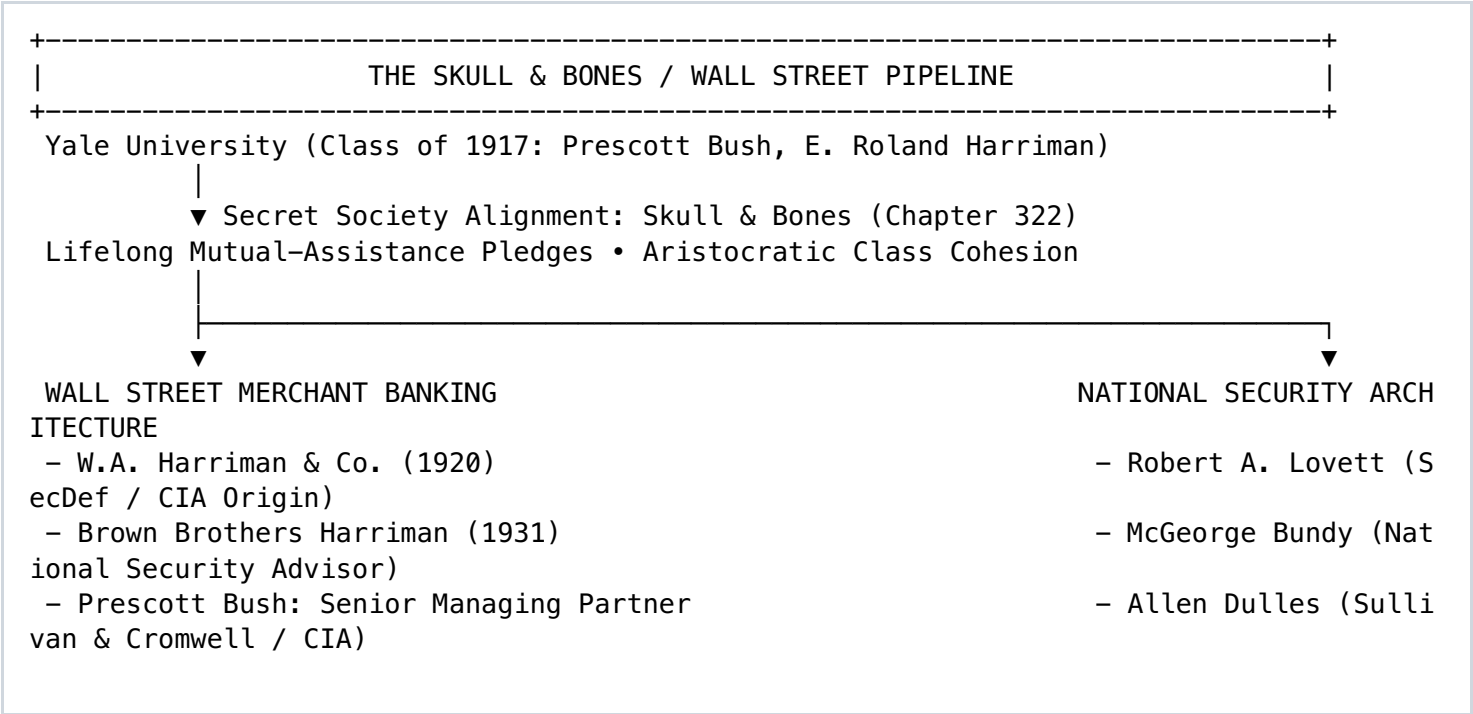
DOCUMENT INDEX

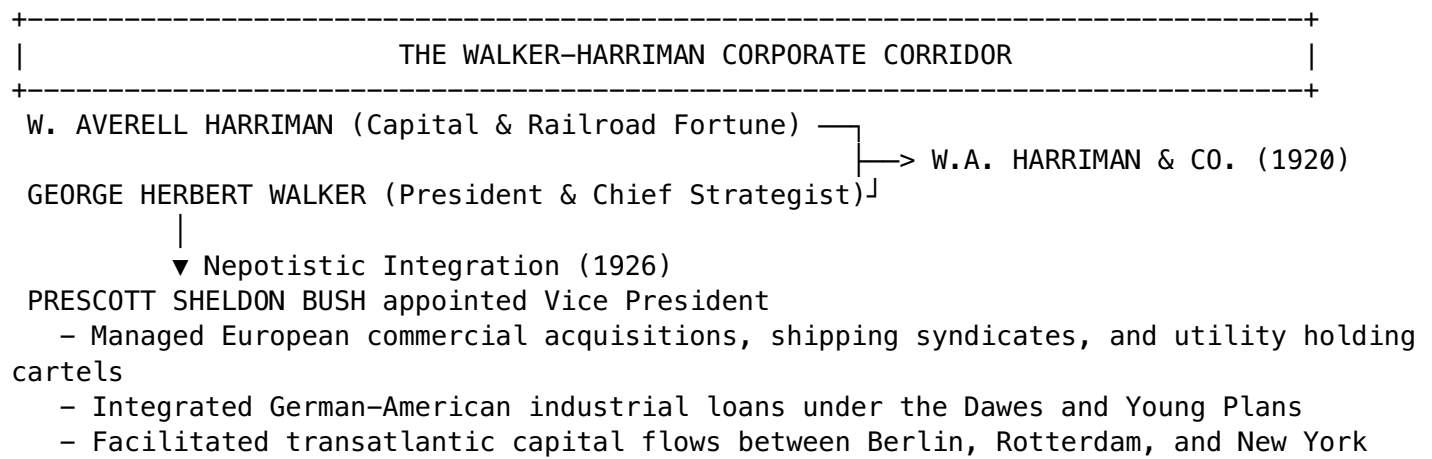
1. The Ivy League Grooming: Yale, Skull & Bones (1917) & The Aristocratic Networks
2. The Walker-Harriman Nexus: G.H. Walker & Co., W.A. Harriman & Merchant Banking
3. Brown Brothers Harriman (59 Wall Street): The Private Financial Empire
4. Fritz Thyssen & The German Steel Trust: Underwriting the Re-Armament of the Third Reich
5. Union Banking Corporation (39 Broadway): The Transatlantic Laundering Conduit
6. Silesian-American Corporation: Coal, Zinc & Slave Labor in the Polish Corridor
7. The 1942 Federal Seizures: Leo Crowley, Vesting Order 248 & The Trading with the Enemy Act
8. The Post-War Liquidation Windfall: Financing Zapata Petroleum & Dresser Industries
9. The Senate Years: Prescott Bush, Dwight D. Eisenhower & The National Security Council
10. Forensic Asset-Tracing Audit & Transnational Banking Complicity Checklist

1. THE IVY LEAGUE GROOMING: YALE, SKULL & BONES (1917)

Prescott Sheldon Bush entered Yale University in 1913, inheriting the social standing established by his father's rail and steel connections. At Yale, Bush was tapped for the secretive senior society **Skull and Bones** (Class of 1917), an institution whose membership formed an interlocking directorate across the American diplomatic corps, Wall Street investment houses, and the emerging intelligence establishment.

Among his cohort and close campus circle were individuals who would later direct American military and geopolitical power: **E. Roland Harriman** (younger brother of W. Averell Harriman), **Robert A. Lovett** (later Secretary of Defense and a key architect of the Central Intelligence Agency), and prominent members of the Whitney, Bundy, and Rockefeller circles.





Under Bert Walker's patronage, Prescott Bush was brought into W.A. Harriman & Co. in 1926 as a vice president, operating out of their primary Manhattan offices at **39 Broadway**. His assignment was clear: manage the consolidation of European industrial assets, coordinate corporate restructuring, and channel American investment capital into interwar Europe.

3. BROWN BROTHERS HARRIMAN: 59 WALL STREET

In the wake of the 1929 stock market crash, the American banking sector underwent consolidation. On January 1, 1931, W.A. Harriman & Co. merged with the historic British-American private merchant bank *Brown Brothers & Company*, establishing **Brown Brothers Harriman & Co. (BBH)** at 59 Wall Street.

BBH became the largest private, unincorporated partnership bank in the United States. Unlike publicly traded commercial banks governed by the Glass-Steagall Act, private merchant partnerships operated with high discretion, shielded from public disclosure requirements and regulatory scrutiny.

Partner / Director	Primary Corporate / Political Function	Transatlantic Industrial Connection
Prescott S. Bush	Senior Managing Partner, Operations Director	Director: Union Banking Corp, Dresser Industries, Silesian-American Corp.
W. Averell Harriman	Senior Founding Partner; Diplomat	U.S. Ambassador to the Soviet Union; Marshall Plan Administrator; NY Governor.
E. Roland Harriman	Senior Managing Partner	President of the American Red Cross; Rail trust financier.
Robert A. Lovett	Partner (Skull & Bones 1918)	Assistant Secretary of War for Air (WWII); U.S. Secretary of Defense.
George Herbert Walker	Executive Director & International Dealmaker	Hamburg-Amerika Line; American Ship & Commerce Corporation.

The Legal Hand of Sullivan & Cromwell

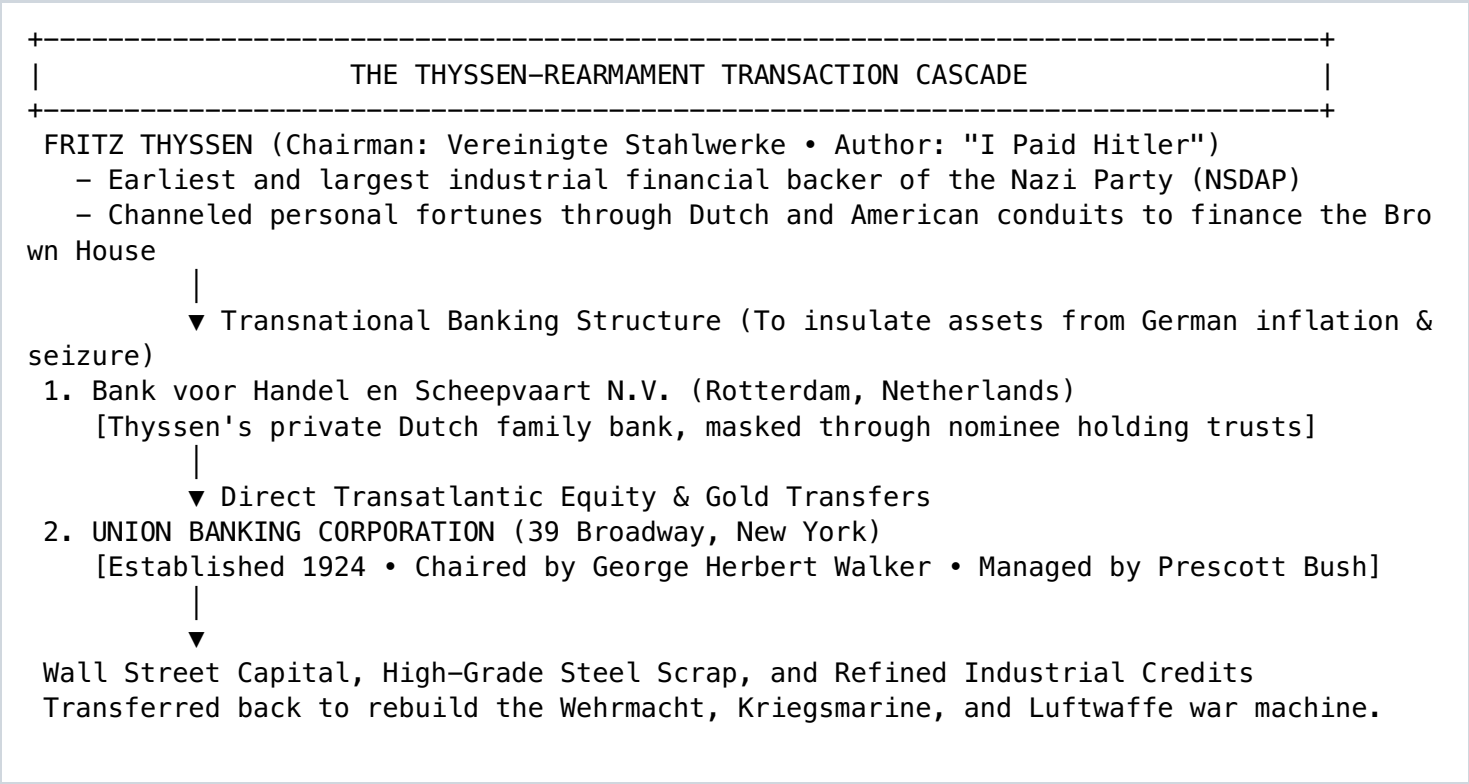
The complex international holding companies, foreign stock trusts, and cross-border shell subsidiaries used by Brown Brothers Harriman were designed by their legal counsel: **Sullivan & Cromwell**, led by senior partners **John Foster Dulles** and his brother **Allen Welsh Dulles**.

The Dulles brothers specialized in designing corporate structures that masked German beneficial ownership within American and Dutch front companies, creating a legal firewall between Wall Street capital and European industrial syndicates.

4. FRITZ THYSSEN & THE GERMAN STEEL TRUST: VEREINIGTE STAHLWERKE

The principal foreign client that enriched the Harriman-Bush-Walker network was the German steel magnate **Fritz Thyssen**, head of the industrial conglomerate **Vereinigte Stahlwerke (United**

Steelworks). Established in 1926, the trust controlled over 75% of Germany’s domestic iron ore reserves and produced over 40% of the country’s raw steel, 45% of its structural plates, and a vast share of its coal and military forgings.



The Documentary Confession: "I Paid Hitler"

In his published memoirs, *I Paid Hitler* (1941), Fritz Thyssen openly acknowledged his financial role:

Archival Extract: Fritz Thyssen
Testimony

Industrial Cartel Documentation • Rhineland
Metallurgy

"In October 1923, I paid 100,000 gold marks to the National Socialist party... Through the Bank voor Handel en Scheepvaart in Rotterdam, large credits were opened and transferred to the accounts of the party leadership in Munich."

Historical Reality: The Rotterdam bank through which Thyssen channeled these funds was the parent entity of the **Union Banking Corporation** in New York, whose directorship, voting stock, and daily management were shared by Prescott Bush.

5. UNION BANKING CORPORATION: 39 BROADWAY

The **Union Banking Corporation (UBC)** was incorporated under New York State banking laws in 1924, listing its principal place of business at **39 Broadway**—the headquarters of W.A. Harriman & Co. (and later Brown Brothers Harriman).

UBC was not a traditional consumer retail bank; it operated as a closed clearinghouse and corporate trust bank for the Thyssen family empire and their affiliated shipping, coal, and steel cartels.

+-----+ UNION BANKING CORPORATION BOARD OF DIRECTORS (1934–1942) +-----+	
PRESCOTT SHELDON BUSH: Director & Managing Partner (Brown Brothers Harriman) E. ROLAND HARRIMAN: Director & Vice President (Brown Brothers Harriman) CORNELIS LIEVENSE: President (Dutch National representing Thyssen interests) H. DUDLEY COPLAND: Director H.J. KOUWENHOVEN: Director (Managing Director: Bank voor Handel en Scheepvaart) JOHANN G. GROENINGEN: Director (German industrial liaison)	
Corporate Stock Ledger: - 4,000 total shares authorized and issued. - Over 98% of shares held by nominee directors for the beneficial ownership of: BANK VOOR HANDEL EN SCHEEPVAART N.V. (Rotterdam) / FRITZ THYSSEN. - Prescott S. Bush held one share of qualifying voting stock in his own name.	

The Interlocking Operations at 39 Broadway

The corporate interlock was tight: Prescott Bush managed the day-to-day operations of the bank, approved lines of credit, and coordinated the clearance of raw material shipments, high-grade steel scrap, and industrial coal between Thyssen’s holdings in occupied Europe and international commodity markets.

Even after the German invasion of Poland in September 1939 triggered World War II in Europe, UBC continued to operate without interruption, processing millions of dollars in financial transactions for the German industrial cartel through its Manhattan accounts.

6. SILESIAN-AMERICAN CORP & THE POLISH CORRIDOR

Beyond the Union Banking Corporation, Prescott Bush held operational responsibilities as a director of the **Silesian-American Corporation**, alongside his father-in-law George Herbert Walker.

Incorporated in Delaware in 1926 by W.A. Harriman & Co., Silesian-American held controlling equity in **Consolidated Silesian Steel Corporation**, a massive coal-mining and zinc-processing conglomerate located in the rich mineral basin of Upper Silesia, along the German-Polish border.

Industrial Asset	Geographic Location	Primary Military / Strategic Product	Labor Extraction Profile
Consolidated Silesian Steel Corp	Upper Silesia (Katowice / Oświęcim region)	High-grade metallurgical coking coal, industrial zinc, structural steel	Forced labor drawn from surrounding detention and concentration complexes.
American Ship & Commerce Corp	Transatlantic Maritime Lines (New York / Hamburg)	Dual-use cargo transit, commercial intelligence transport	Operated in direct partnership with Emil Helfferich (Nazi shipping chairman).
Seamless Steel Equipment Corp	New York / Pennsylvania / German distribution	High-pressure seamless steel tubes, torpedo casings, boiler cylinders	Direct subsidiary of Thyssen's Vereinigte Stahlwerke; seized by U.S. in 1942.

The Proximity to Oświęcim (Auschwitz)

The industrial assets controlled by Silesian-American Corporation were situated in the direct vicinity of **Oświęcim** (later renamed Auschwitz by the German occupation). Following the 1939 Nazi blitzkrieg and the partitioning of Poland, the Silesian industrial complex was integrated into the German re-armament ministry under Albert Speer.

The complex utilized enslaved populations from the nearby concentration camps for coal extraction and heavy metallurgy. Prescott Bush remained on the corporate board of directors of Silesian-American throughout this period, until the company's German-linked assets were seized by the United States government.

7. THE 1942 FEDERAL SEIZURES: TRADING WITH THE ENEMY ACT

On December 7, 1941, the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor brought the United States into formal hostilities with the Axis powers. Germany declared war on the United States four days later, on December 11, 1941. Under federal wartime legislation, all commercial, financial, and trade relations with enemy nations and their corporate fronts were declared illegal under the **Trading with the Enemy Act of 1917** (50 U.S.C. App.).

Despite the state of war, the Union Banking Corporation remained open at 39 Broadway, holding Axis assets, managing corporate trusts, and functioning as an American financial bridge for Thyssen-controlled entities.

**Office of Alien Property Custodian:
Vesting Order No. 248**

Signed: Leo T. Crowley • Executed: October 20, 1942 • 7 Fed. Reg. 8597

"Under the authority of the Trading with the Enemy Act, as amended... all right, title, and interest of Bank voor Handel en Scheepvaart, N.V., in and to 4,000 shares of common capital stock of Union Banking Corporation, a New York corporation... is hereby vested in the Alien Property Custodian of the United States."

Official Finding: *"Finding that the said Union Banking Corporation is owned or controlled by or held for the benefit of... nationals of a designated enemy country (Germany)."*

Action: The federal government formally seized the bank, its vaults, its assets, and its stock certificates. Prescott Bush was stripped of his directorship by executive decree.

The Subsequent Seizure Orders

The federal crackdown did not stop with Union Banking Corporation. In the weeks that followed, the Alien Property Custodian issued additional vesting orders targeting the surrounding network:

- **Vesting Order No. 259 (October 1942):** Seized *Holland-American Trading Corporation* (a front firm managed through 39 Broadway).
- **Vesting Order No. 261 (October 1942):** Seized *Seamless Steel Equipment Corporation* (a direct Thyssen front).
- **Vesting Order No. 370 (November 1942):** Seized the Nazi-controlled stock in *Silesian-American Corporation*, terminating Prescott Bush's management role over the Silesian mining properties.

CHRONOLOGY OF FEDERAL SEIZURES (OCT–NOV 1942)

Dec 11, 1941: United States & Nazi Germany enter official state of total war



▼ 10 Months of Continued Operations at 39 Broadway

Oct 20, 1942: VESTING ORDER 248 → Seizure of UNION BANKING CORPORATION

Oct 28, 1942: VESTING ORDER 259 → Seizure of HOLLAND–AMERICAN TRADING CORP

Nov 06, 1942: VESTING ORDER 261 → Seizure of SEAMLESS STEEL EQUIPMENT CORP

Nov 17, 1942: VESTING ORDER 370 → Seizure of SILESIAN–AMERICAN CORPORATION



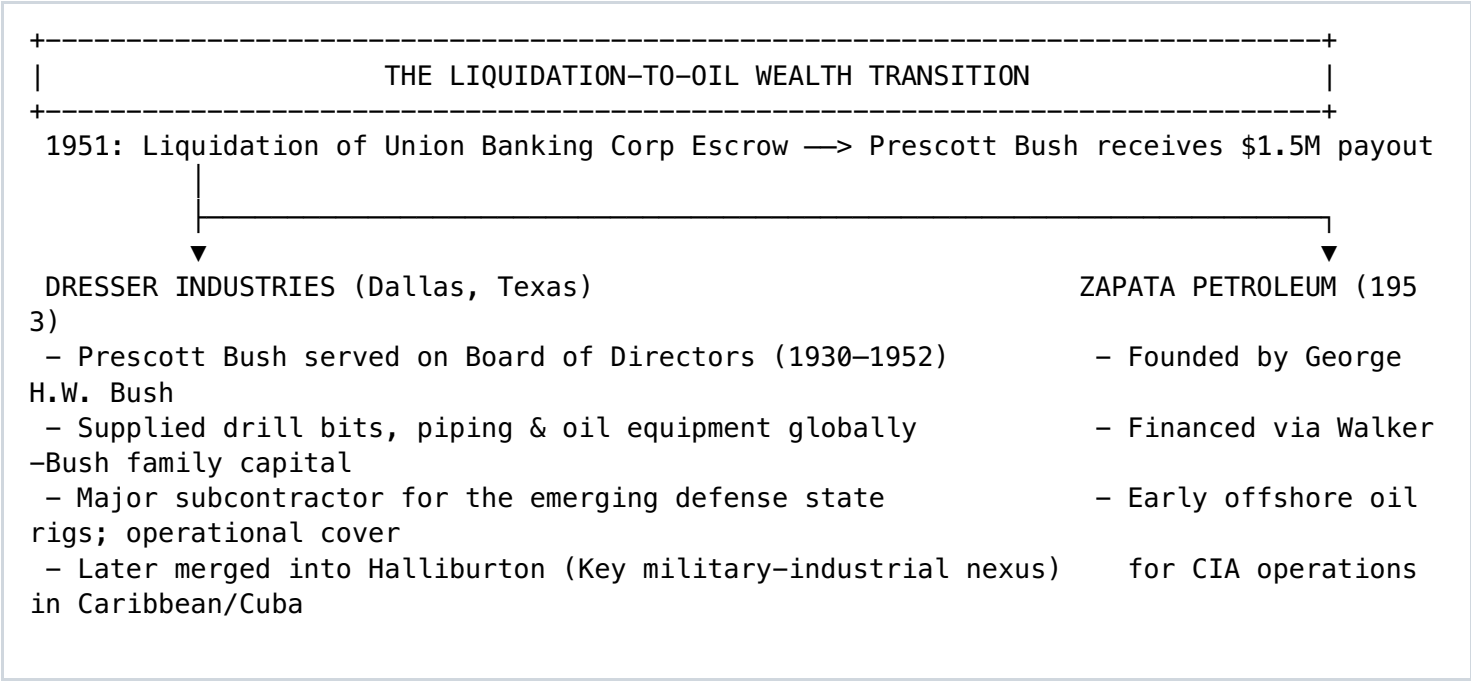
THE HISTORICAL SUPPRESSION:

To protect the reputation of Brown Brothers Harriman and high-level figures like Averell Harriman (serving as President Roosevelt's special envoy to Churchill and Stalin), the Justice Department declined to file criminal treason indictments. The assets were impounded; the executives quietly returned to Wall Street.

8. POST-WAR LIQUIDATION: DRESSER & TEXAS PETROLEUM

The seizure of Union Banking Corporation's shares did not result in the permanent forfeiture of the underlying capital. Following the conclusion of World War II, the Alien Property Custodian held the assets in federal escrow pending legal and financial settlement.

In **1951**, the federal government liquidated the remaining assets of the Union Banking Corporation. As a shareholder of record, Prescott Bush received a cash distribution from the liquidation of approximately **\$1,500,000** (equivalent to over \$18 million today)—a windfall derived from an enterprise that had been seized for servicing enemy industrial cartels.



The Launch of George H.W. Bush

This financial windfall, coupled with Brown Brothers Harriman credit lines, directly capitalized his son, **George Herbert Walker Bush**. Rather than following his father onto the trading floor of Wall Street, G.H.W. Bush took his family inheritance to the Permian Basin of West Texas, co-founding *Zapata Petroleum* in 1953 and later spinning off *Zapata Off-Shore Company*.

These offshore drilling assets in the Caribbean and the Gulf of Mexico provided logistical infrastructure, maritime cover, and financial foundations that intersected with early American intelligence operations in the region, paving the way for G.H.W. Bush’s subsequent rise to Director of Central Intelligence (CIA) in 1976.

9. THE SENATE YEARS: EISENHOWER & THE SECURITY STATE

With his family fortune secured, Prescott Bush transitioned into direct political office. After a narrow defeat in 1950, he was elected to the **United States Senate from Connecticut in 1952**, serving until January 1963.

In Washington, Bush was an establishment insider, playing regular rounds of golf with President **Dwight D. Eisenhower** and serving as an influential voice on the Senate Banking and Currency Committee and the Joint Economic Committee.

Legislative / Political Initiative	Public Narrative	Institutional Reality
National Interstate Highway Act (1956)	Modernization of civilian transportation	Heavily promoted by Bush; generated contracts for oil, asphalt, and steel cartels; prioritized military mobilization routes.
Senate Armed Services Support	Strong Cold War anti-communist defense	Shielded private aerospace and defense contractors (e.g., United Aircraft/Pratt & Whitney in CT) from congressional cost-control audits.
Lobbying for Private Banking	Defending sound money and fiscal conservatism	Blocked efforts to subject private merchant banks (like BBH) to standard commercial bank transparency rules.
Backing of Richard Nixon (1952–1960)	Party unity and vice-presidential sponsorship	Prescott Bush was an early financial patron of Richard Nixon, cementing alliances that served his family across subsequent decades.

The Architect of the Modern Dynastic Network

Prescott Bush understood the triad of modern governance: **private merchant banking, intelligence networks, and federal executive authority**.

He kept his family name untarnished by the 1942 Alien Property Custodian seizures by relying on cooperative corporate media relationships, leveraging personal friendships with figures like CBS chairman William S. Paley, and preserving family capital within discrete trusts that funded two subsequent American presidencies.

10. FORENSIC AUDIT CHECKLIST: CORPORATE COMPLICITY AUDITS

For independent intelligence analysts, forensic accountants, and investigative historians, the historical record of Prescott Bush and the Union Banking Corporation provides a model for tracing transnational financial complicity during geopolitical conflict:

- [] **Analyze Cross-Border Nominee Shareholder Books:** Scrutinize the share registries of international private banks to identify whether domestic nominal directors hold equity on behalf of foreign trusts or front banks.
- [] **Cross-Reference Alien Property Custodian Files:** Search *National Archives Record Group 131* (Office of Alien Property) for historical vesting orders, corporate depositions, and post-war liquidation settlements.
- [] **Map the Interlocking Directorates of Private Merchant Banks:** Trace how managing partners of private unincorporated partnerships (like Brown Brothers Harriman) hold concurrent board seats in defense, heavy steel, and energy extraction firms.
- [] **Follow Post-Seizure Escrow Dispersals:** Track the movement of capital from liquidated wartime trusts to determine which domestic corporate entities were funded by released foreign assets.
- [] **Audit the Interface Between Corporate Law and Intelligence Agencies:** Examine the law firms (e.g., Sullivan & Cromwell) that structure cross-border holding vehicles; track whether their senior partners move directly into state intelligence leadership (e.g., Allen Dulles).
- [] **Investigate Industrial Facilities Near Detention Sites:** When evaluating corporate operations in occupied territory, cross-index corporate mining and steel concessions with wartime labor camps to identify complicity in forced labor regimes.
- [] **Scrutinize Dynastic Political Capitalization:** Trace modern political campaign war-chests and private family investment offices back through post-war industrial windfalls to expose the financial roots of modern political dynasties.